

EXECUTIVE · ARCHITECTURE · LEADERSHIP SERIES

COMMUNICATION

FRAMEWORKS MASTER GUIDE

For Enterprise Architects · Principal Architects · CTO Candidates
From Technical Fluency to Board-Level Strategic Communication

Pyramid Principle

BLUF

SBAR

SCR

5 Whys

PREP

Minto Pyramid

SBI Feedback

STAR

The Burning Platform

Risk-Adjusted Narrative

AUDIENCE LEVELS COVERED

Board · C-Suite · Executive Committee · Engineering · Operations · Regulators

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This guide covers every communication framework an Enterprise Architect or CTO-level leader needs to master. Each framework includes its structure, when to use it, worked examples at executive level, common mistakes, and a contrast between strong and weak application.

SECTION 01

THE COMMUNICATION PYRAMID

Every communication framework rests on one foundational insight: the audience determines the structure, the register, the length, and the level of abstraction. Architects who communicate the same way to a board member and a software engineer will fail with both. Mastering communication means developing fluency across the full spectrum — and switching registers instantly and invisibly.

THE FIVE REGISTERS

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Board / Investors	Strategic direction	Why this matters to the enterprise	Maximum	3 minutes / 1 page
C-Suite (CEO, CFO)	Decision support	What to decide and the risk of each option	High	5 minutes / 2 pages
VP / Director	Alignment	What we're doing and what they need to do	Medium	10 minutes / 4 pages
Engineering Leaders	Coordination	How we're doing it and the constraints	Low	30 minutes / detailed
Regulators / Audit	Assurance	Evidence of control and compliance	Formal	As required / documented

THE CARDINAL RULE

Never communicate at the level of your thinking. Communicate at the level of your audience's decision. Your job is not to show how hard the problem is — it is to make the decision or action obvious.

REGISTER MATCH ✓ Opens with the outcome or decision needed. ✓ Uses the audience's vocabulary, not yours. ✓ Length calibrated to the audience's time. ✓ Complexity hidden, clarity front-loaded.	REGISTER MISMATCH ✗ Opens with context, history, or technical detail. ✗ Uses architecture or engineering vocabulary with executives. ✗ Overlong for the audience's patience. ✗ Makes the audience work to find the point.
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SECTION 02

PP

Pyramid Principle / Minto Pyramid

Origin: Barbara Minto, McKinsey & Company, 1970s

Use when: Any written or verbal communication where the audience needs a clear recommendation, especially executives who read horizontally before vertically.

THE STRUCTURE

①	Governing Thought	The single most important thing you want the audience to take away. One sentence. Answerable in one sentence. This goes first, always.
②	Key Lines	The three to five arguments or reasons that support the governing thought. Each must be mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive (MECE). They answer 'Why?' or 'How?' relative to the governing thought.
③	Supporting Detail	The evidence, data, and analysis that support each key line. This is the bottom of the pyramid — it exists to justify the key lines, not to be read in full by executives.

WORKED EXAMPLE — ARCHITECTURE MODERNISATION CASE

PYRAMID APPLIED

→ GOVERNING THOUGHT: We must modernise our core banking platform in 24 months or risk regulatory action and a 40% increase in the cost of product delivery.

→ KEY LINE 1: The current platform is materially non-compliant with three incoming regulatory requirements.

→ KEY LINE 2: Our delivery cost per feature has grown 38% in two years due to technical debt on the current platform.

→ KEY LINE 3: Competitor platforms built on modern architecture are delivering equivalent features in one-third of our time-to-market.

→ SUPPORTING DETAIL: [Regulatory citations, cost analysis, competitive benchmarks — available in appendix]

THE SCQA VARIANT — SITUATION · COMPLICATION · QUESTION · ANSWER

For strategic communications that require a narrative setup before the recommendation, use SCQA as the entry point into the pyramid.

S	Situation	Establish common ground — what both you and the audience already know to be true.
C	Complication	Introduce the change, threat, or problem that disrupts the situation.
Q	Question	Surface the question the complication naturally raises in the audience's mind.
A	Answer	Deliver your governing thought as the direct answer to that question.

STRONG APPLICATION ✓ Recommendation in the first sentence. ✓ Key lines are genuinely MECE. ✓ Detail in appendix — not in the main narrative. ✓ Board reads the governing thought and key lines only.	WEAK APPLICATION ✗ Builds to the recommendation over multiple pages. ✗ Key lines overlap or leave gaps. ✗ Evidence embedded in the narrative — buries the point. ✗ Audience must read everything to find the recommendation.
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SECTION 03

BL
UF

Bottom Line Up Front

Origin: US Military, adapted for executive communication

Use when: Any situation where you have 60 seconds or less — verbal briefings, email subject lines, Slack messages to executives, and opening statements.

THE STRUCTURE

B	Bottom Line	State the conclusion, decision, or action required — in the very first sentence. No preamble. No context-setting. The answer first.
L	Level	Pitch the detail at the correct level for the audience. Add only enough context to make the bottom line credible.
U	Urgency	State the timeline or decision deadline explicitly. When does this need a response? What happens if it doesn't get one?
F	Follow-up	State the specific action you need from the recipient. Not 'let me know your thoughts' — a specific, time-bound request.

WORKED EXAMPLES

BEFORE BLUF

✗ WEAK: 'Hi Sarah, I wanted to follow up on our discussion last week about the cloud migration programme. As you know, we've been working through several options and the team has done a thorough analysis. I thought it would be helpful to share some of the findings...'

AFTER BLUF

✓ STRONG: 'Sarah — we need a go/no-go decision on cloud provider by Friday 5pm. AWS is our recommended option based on cost, compliance posture, and migration risk. Delay beyond Friday pushes our Q2 launch by six weeks. Can you confirm approval or schedule 20 minutes to discuss blockers?'

BLUF FOR EMAIL SUBJECT LINES

Executive email is scanned, not read. The subject line must contain the bottom line.

SUBJECT LINE TRANSFORMATION

→ WEAK SUBJECT: 'Cloud Migration Update'

→ STRONG SUBJECT: 'DECISION NEEDED by Fri: Cloud Provider — AWS Recommended'

→ WEAK SUBJECT: 'Re: Architecture Review Board Meeting'

→ STRONG SUBJECT: 'ARB APPROVED: Payment Platform Modernisation — Phase 1 Green'

→ WEAK SUBJECT: 'Technical Debt Analysis'

→ STRONG SUBJECT: 'ACTION: £4M Technical Debt Risk Requires CFO Sign-off by EOW'

SECTION 04

SB

AR

Situation · Background · Assessment · Recommendation

Origin: US Navy / Healthcare, adapted for technology leadership

Use when: High-stakes briefings, incident communication, regulatory updates, and any situation where the audience needs to take action quickly.

THE STRUCTURE

S	Situation	What is happening right now? One to two sentences. State the current state clearly and factually.
B	Background	What context does the audience need to understand the situation? Only what is relevant — not a full history.
A	Assessment	What is your professional judgement of the situation? What does it mean? What is the severity? What are the options?
R	Recommendation	What specific action do you recommend? By whom? By when? What is the consequence of inaction?

WORKED EXAMPLE — SECURITY INCIDENT ESCALATION

S	Situation	At 14:23 today, our security monitoring detected unauthorised access to the customer data environment. Approximately 40,000 customer records may have been exposed.
B	Background	The access was via a compromised service account created during last month's infrastructure migration. The account had broader permissions than required. We identified this through routine anomaly detection.
A	Assessment	This is a high-severity incident with regulatory notification obligations under GDPR Article 33. The 72-hour notification window begins now. The access has been contained. Customer impact is under assessment but may require direct notification.
R	Recommendation	I recommend: (1) legal and compliance engaged immediately, (2) ICO notification drafted by 17:00 today, (3) CEO informed before end of business. I need your authorisation to proceed. Decision needed in the next 30 minutes.

SBAR STRENGTHS ✓ Forces completeness — situation, context, and action. ✓ Works under extreme time pressure. ✓ Used by the audience receiving the briefing — they know the structure. ✓ Prevents the common failure of reporting without recommending.	SBAR LIMITATIONS ✗ Too structured for relationship communication. ✗ Can feel clinical in emotionally sensitive situations. ✗ Not suitable for exploratory or ambiguous conversations. ✗ Requires that you have a recommendation — don't use it if you don't.
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SECTION 05

SC
R

Situation · Complication · Resolution

Origin: Narrative storytelling tradition, adapted for business communication

Use when: Strategic presentations, investment cases, transformation narratives, and any communication that needs to generate urgency before the recommendation.

THE STRUCTURE

S	Situation	Establish the stable world that the audience recognises. This is common ground — what everyone already knows and agrees on.
C	Complication	Introduce the disruption: the change, the threat, the gap, or the risk that means the current situation cannot continue. This is where you create urgency.
R	Resolution	Present your recommendation as the answer to the complication. The resolution should feel inevitable given the complication.

WHY SCR WORKS NEUROLOGICALLY

The human brain is a narrative processing machine. We understand the world through story structure — stable state, disruption, resolution. When you structure a business communication as SCR, you work with the brain's natural processing rather than against it. The complication creates a cognitive gap that the brain is compelled to close — making your resolution feel earned rather than imposed.

WORKED EXAMPLE — PLATFORM INVESTMENT CASE

S	Situation	For the past five years, our technology platform has supported strong growth. We have delivered 40 new products and grown revenue by 180%. Our engineering teams are experienced and our architecture has served us well.
C	Complication	The same architecture that enabled our growth is now becoming our constraint. Delivery cycle times have doubled in three years. Our largest competitor launched six equivalent features last quarter in the time it took us to launch two. Three regulatory requirements due in 18 months cannot be built on our current platform without fundamental redesign — at greater cost than a planned modernisation.
R	Resolution	A two-year platform modernisation programme, funded at £18M, will restore our delivery velocity, eliminate the regulatory risk, and position us to deliver the next five years of growth. The cost of inaction — continued velocity degradation, regulatory exposure, and competitive disadvantage — exceeds £40M over the same period.

CRAFT PRINCIPLES

- The Situation must be genuinely stable — if you introduce tension in the Situation, the Complication loses its impact.
- The Complication must be specific and credible — vague threats do not create urgency.
- The Resolution must flow directly from the Complication — it should be the obvious answer, not a surprise.
- Use data in the Complication — numbers make threats concrete and memorable.

SECTION 06

PREP

Point · Reason · Example · Point*Origin: Debate and advocacy training**Use when: Verbal communication under pressure — Q&A; sessions, board challenges, panel discussions, and any situation requiring a structured oral response in 60–90 seconds.*

THE STRUCTURE

P	Point	State your position in one clear sentence. No preamble. No 'that's a great question.' Straight to the point.
R	Reason	Give the single strongest reason your position is correct. Not three reasons — one. The best one.
E	Example	Ground the reason in a specific, concrete example or data point. Abstract reasoning without evidence is not persuasive at executive level.
P	Point	Restate your position — now reinforced by the reason and example. This closes the loop and drives the point home.

WORKED EXAMPLE — BOARD CHALLENGE

PREP IN ACTION

BOARD MEMBER: 'Why should we trust your team to deliver this when the last platform programme was two years late?'

P — POINT: 'The programme design is fundamentally different from the one that ran over.'

R — REASON: 'The previous programme tried to do everything at once — 47 workstreams, no staged gating, and a fixed scope. This programme is staged: each phase must prove value before funding is released for the next.'

E — EXAMPLE: 'Phase 1 is three months and £2M. It delivers one measurable outcome: payment processing latency below 200ms. If we miss that, the programme stops. That gate structure did not exist before.'

P — POINT: 'The architecture of this programme prevents the failure mode of the last one. I am accountable for that design, and I am confident it holds.'

PREP UNDER TIME PRESSURE

PREP is designed for the 60-second executive response. When challenged, the instinct is to add more context. PREP prevents this — it forces you to select the single strongest argument and deploy it with precision. Practice PREP until it is automatic. You should be able to structure any oral response in PREP within five seconds of hearing the question.

PREP DISCIPLINE RULES

- Time: 60–90 seconds maximum per PREP response.
- Reason: choose one — the strongest. Adding three reasons dilutes all three.
- Example: must be specific. 'We've seen this before' is not an example.
- Second Point: do not introduce new information — close, don't continue.
- Recovery: if challenged after your PREP response, deploy a second PREP rather than extending the first.

SECTION 07

SBI**Situation · Behaviour · Impact**

Origin: Center for Creative Leadership

*Use when: Delivering feedback to peers, senior engineers, and leaders — especially in situations where the behaviour has had a visible negative impact.***THE STRUCTURE**

S	Situation	Anchor the feedback to a specific, observable situation. When and where did it happen? Be precise — avoid 'you always' or 'you never.'
B	Behaviour	Describe only the observable behaviour — what you saw or heard. Not your interpretation. Not their intention. Only what happened.
I	Impact	Describe the impact of that behaviour — on the team, the decision, the outcome, or on you. This is where you connect the behaviour to why it matters.

WORKED EXAMPLES — SENIOR ARCHITECT FEEDBACK**SBI EXAMPLE — PSYCHOLOGICAL SAFETY**

SITUATION: 'In yesterday's design review, when the junior engineer presented the API proposal...'

BEHAVIOUR: '...you interrupted them three times before they completed their first slide, and you characterised their approach as naïve without asking any questions.'

IMPACT: 'The engineer stopped contributing for the rest of the session. Two other junior engineers in the room told me afterwards they are now reluctant to present in reviews. We lose the perspectives we most need to hear.'

WHY SBI WORKS

SBI works because it is irrefutable at the Situation and Behaviour levels — you are reporting observation, not interpretation. The recipient cannot argue with what happened. They can only engage with the Impact, which opens the conversation. It removes the most common feedback failure: character judgements ('you're dismissive') that trigger defensiveness and close the conversation.

SBI DONE WELL

- ✓ Situation is specific — date, meeting, event.
- ✓ Behaviour is observable — seen or heard, not inferred.
- ✓ Impact is real — on people, decisions, or outcomes.
- ✓ Delivered promptly — within 24–48 hours of the event.

SBI DONE POORLY

- ✗ Situation is vague — 'you often do this.'
- ✗ Behaviour is interpreted — 'you were trying to undermine me.'
- ✗ Impact is about your feelings only — no organisational consequence.
- ✗ Delivered weeks later, attached to a performance review.

SECTION 08

BP

The Burning Platform Framework

Origin: Daryl Conner, Managing at the Speed of Change, 1993

Use when: Creating urgency for transformation and change — when the status quo is genuinely dangerous but the organisation has not yet recognised it.

The Burning Platform metaphor describes a North Sea oil worker who jumped from a burning platform into freezing water — choosing certain discomfort over certain death. Conner used it to explain why people change: not because the new state is attractive, but because the current state is intolerable. This framework is for creating that recognition in an organisation or executive audience.

THE THREE ELEMENTS

1	The Platform is Burning	Make the cost of inaction visible, specific, and time-bound. Vague threats do not create urgency. Quantified, dated consequences do. 'We risk regulatory action by Q3 if we do not act' is a burning platform. 'We have technical debt' is not.
2	The Jump is Survivable	Define the transformation as achievable, not just necessary. If the audience believes the jump will kill them, they stay on the platform. Your case must include evidence that the change is deliverable — comparable examples, staged milestones, and risk mitigation.
3	Staying is Not an Option	Remove the third alternative — doing nothing. Present the cost of inaction at least as prominently as the cost of change. The audience must believe that the current trajectory leads to a worse outcome than the disruption of transformation.

ETHICAL GUARDRAILS

The Burning Platform is a powerful framework that can be misused. Use it only when the urgency is genuine — manufactured urgency erodes trust permanently when it is discovered. If you have to exaggerate the threat to create urgency, the problem is not the communication; it is the strategy. Revisit whether the initiative is genuinely necessary.

BURNING vs NOT BURNING

The platform IS burning: 'Our three largest competitors have launched AI-native products in the past six months. Our largest customer has issued an RFP that our current platform cannot respond to. If we do not have a credible AI capability by Q4, we are not on the shortlist.'

The platform IS NOT burning: 'AI is transforming every industry and we need to move fast or we will be left behind.' [Too vague — no specific threat, no timeline, no evidence]

SECTION 09

RA
N

Risk-Adjusted Narrative

Origin: Executive communication practice, uncertainty management

Use when: Any situation where you must communicate genuinely uncertain outcomes to an audience that desires certainty — boards, investment committees, regulatory bodies.

THE STRUCTURE

1	Anchor	State your current best estimate clearly and directly. Do not bury it in caveats. Give the number, the outcome, or the recommendation first.
2	Range	Provide a confidence-weighted range — not a single point estimate. Name the upper and lower bounds and what drives the variance.
3	Assumptions	State the two or three key assumptions the estimate rests on. Explicit assumptions are more credible than hidden ones.
4	Uncertainty Type	Distinguish aleatory uncertainty (irreducible variability) from epistemic uncertainty (knowable with more analysis). Show what actions will reduce the uncertainty.
5	Decision Gate	Propose a specific checkpoint where the uncertainty will be materially reduced and the estimate revised. This converts open-ended uncertainty into managed risk.

WORKED EXAMPLE — INVESTMENT CASE WITH UNCERTAINTY

RISK-ADJUSTED NARRATIVE APPLIED

→ ANCHOR: Our current estimate for the modernisation programme is £14M over 24 months.

→ RANGE: The range is £11M–£18M, depending primarily on the complexity of the legacy data migration.

→ ASSUMPTIONS: This estimate assumes (1) no significant regulatory requirement changes in the period, (2) third-party API dependencies remain stable, and (3) we can recruit four senior engineers at market rate within 60 days.

→ UNCERTAINTY TYPE: The data migration complexity is epistemic — we will know more after a 6-week discovery spike. The regulatory environment is aleatory — we cannot eliminate it but have built a 15% contingency.

→ DECISION GATE: We will return to the board at week 8 with a revised estimate after the discovery spike. At that point the range narrows to approximately ±10%.

Executives who communicate false precision get short-term approval and long-term credibility damage when reality diverges from the forecast. The Risk-Adjusted Narrative builds credibility by being accurately uncertain rather than precisely wrong.

SECTION 10

SR

F

Stakeholder Register Framework

Origin: Programme management and executive communication practice

Use when: Before any major communication — board paper, investment case, transformation narrative, or difficult conversation — to ensure the message is tailored to each audience.

THE AUDIENCE MATRIX

AUDIENCE	REGISTER	FOCUS	LENGTH	TONE
Board	Strategic	Why this matters to the enterprise and its risk profile	3 min	Measured, confident, decisive
CEO	Executive	What to decide and what I need from you	5 min	Direct, business-outcome focused
CFO	Financial	What does this cost, what is the return, and what is the risk	10 min	Quantified, scenario-based
CIO/CTO	Technical	What are we building and what are the risks and dependencies	30 min	Structured, rigorous, options-based
CISO	Risk	What are the security and compliance implications	20 min	Risk-tiered, compliance-linked
Eng. Leaders	Operational	What are we doing, in what sequence, and what do we need	Detailed	Specific, actionable, technically grounded
Regulators	Formal	Evidence of control, compliance, and governance	Formal	Precise, evidenced, no ambiguity

STAKEHOLDER INFLUENCE MAP

Before any major initiative, map your stakeholders across two axes: decision power (high/low) and disposition (supportive/resistant). This produces four segments that require different communication strategies.

A	High Power / Supportive	Engage deeply. Keep informed. Use as sponsors and validators. Equip them to carry your message to others.
B	High Power / Resistant	Invest most heavily here. Understand the source of resistance. Tailor the narrative to their specific concerns. One-on-one meetings before any group session.
C	Low Power / Supportive	Build the coalition. These are your credibility validators and ground-level advocates. Keep them engaged and visible.
D	Low Power / Resistant	Monitor but do not over-invest. Address their concerns through the high-power stakeholders they align with.

SECTION 11

3LM

The Three-Lens Communication Model

Origin: Executive communication and strategic framing practice

Use when: Framing any technology initiative for an executive or board audience — ensuring the business, risk, and investment dimensions are all covered.

THE THREE LENSES

B	Business Lens	Why does this matter to the business? What customer, revenue, market, or competitive outcome does this enable or protect? This lens is for the CEO and CPO.
R	Risk Lens	What risk does this address or create? Regulatory, security, operational, reputational? What is the cost of inaction? This lens is for the CFO, CRO, CISO, and Board.
I	Investment Lens	What does this cost? What is the return and over what period? What are the staged commitment options? This lens is for the CFO and Audit Committee.

Most architects communicate only through the Business Lens — they explain what the technology does and why it is valuable. Executives who approve investment are equally concerned with the Risk and Investment lenses. A communication that does not address all three leaves questions unanswered — and unanswered questions become objections.

ALL THREE LENSES APPLIED

- BUSINESS: This modernisation restores our product delivery velocity to competitive parity — we can ship features 3x faster and respond to customer needs without 9-month lead times.
- RISK: Without this investment, we face three material risks: regulatory non-compliance (£5M+ fine exposure), inability to respond to the incoming PSD3 requirement, and an 18-month window where a competitor with modern architecture can outpace us in every product category.
- INVESTMENT: £14M over 24 months, with a £6M value realisation in year 3 through reduced delivery cost and platform licensing consolidation. Staged gating at months 6, 12, and 18 limits committed exposure to £4M at each gate.

SECTION 12

OP
F

Objection Pre-emption Framework

Origin: Courtroom advocacy and executive communication

Use when: Major investment cases, board presentations, executive steering committees — any high-stakes communication where objections are predictable.

THE FRAMEWORK

1	Map Objections	Before any major communication, list every objection the audience is likely to raise. Be genuinely adversarial — make the strongest version of each objection.
2	Classify	Sort objections into three categories: (A) objections you can pre-empt in the presentation itself, (B) objections you should prepare PREP responses for, (C) objections that reveal a genuine gap in your proposal.
3	Pre-empt in Content	For Category A objections, address them proactively in your narrative — 'You may be wondering why we chose AWS over Azure — here is our analysis.'
4	Prepare Responses	For Category B objections, have a prepared PREP response ready. Rehearse it until it is fluent and natural.
5	Revise or Disclose	For Category C objections — genuine gaps — either revise the proposal to address them, or disclose the gap with a plan to resolve it. Never hope the audience doesn't notice.

COMMON ARCHITECTURE OBJECTIONS AND PRE-EMPTIONS

OBJECTION HANDLING EXAMPLES

OBJECTION: 'Why didn't you consider [alternative]?' → PRE-EMPTION: Include an explicit options analysis with your recommendation. Show that you considered it, evaluated it, and explain why your recommendation is superior.

OBJECTION: 'This is too expensive.' → PRE-EMPTION: Lead with the cost of inaction. 'At £14M, this programme costs less than the regulatory exposure we face if we do not act, and less than the accumulated delivery cost over three years.'

OBJECTION: 'The last programme ran over — why should we trust this one?' → PRE-EMPTION: Include a specific section on how the governance model of this programme is designed to prevent the failure modes of the previous one. Be explicit about what is different.

SECTION 13

DC
F**Difficult Conversation Framework**

Origin: Harvard Negotiation Project — Difficult Conversations (Stone, Patton, Heen)

Use when: Delivering hard news, managing conflict, giving critical feedback, and any conversation where the stakes are high and emotions are involved.

THE THREE CONVERSATIONS

1	What Happened	Separate the facts from the story you are telling about the facts. In any difficult conversation, both parties have a different story. Start by sharing your view as a perspective, not a truth: 'From where I sit, what I observed was...' not 'What actually happened was...'
2	The Feelings Conversation	Acknowledge the emotional dimension — yours and theirs. Unexpressed feelings drive difficult conversations underground. Naming emotions reduces their power: 'I want to be direct — this conversation matters to me.'
3	Identity	Understand that difficult conversations threaten identity — for both parties. The other person's resistance is often about protecting their sense of competence, integrity, or belonging. Address this directly.

THE OPENING MOVE

The first 60 seconds of a difficult conversation determine whether it becomes productive or defensive. The opening must signal that you are entering a conversation, not delivering a verdict.

OPENING MOVE CONTRAST

VERDICT OPENING (avoid): 'I wanted to talk to you because your behaviour in the design review yesterday was unacceptable.'

CONVERSATION OPENING (use): 'I wanted to talk about yesterday's design review because I think something happened there that affected the team, and I want to understand it from your perspective before sharing mine.'

PRINCIPLES FOR DIFFICULT CONVERSATIONS

- Prepare the conversation, not your arguments. Know what you want the outcome to be — not just what you want to say.
- Listen for the version of the story you haven't heard. Ask before advocating.
- Name what is difficult: 'This is a hard conversation for me to have, and I want to have it well.'
- End with a shared understanding, not a verdict: 'What would you like to happen from here?'

SECTION 14

WC

S

Executive Written Communication Standards

Origin: C-suite and board communication practice

Use when: Board papers, executive memos, decision notes, architecture decision records, and any written communication to a senior audience.

THE EXECUTIVE MEMO STANDARD

1	Subject Line	State the decision needed or the outcome of reading: 'DECISION: Cloud Provider Selection — AWS Recommended' not 'Cloud Update'.
2	Executive Summary	Three sentences maximum. Recommendation, rationale, and action required. The entire document should be readable from the executive summary alone.
3	Recommendation	State the recommendation before the analysis. Executives read to validate or challenge — they need the recommendation first.
4	Options Considered	Show that you considered alternatives. Include a brief options table with the top two or three options and the key differentiators.
5	Risk & Mitigation	Name the top three risks and the mitigation for each. Do not bury risk in footnotes.
6	Decision Required	State exactly what decision you need, from whom, and by when. Never end a document without a clear next action.

ARCHITECTURE DECISION RECORD (ADR) STANDARD

An ADR is the written artefact of an architectural decision. At executive level, ADRs serve as governance documentation and audit trail. They must be comprehensible to a non-technical executive.

1	Context	What is the situation and the force that requires a decision?
2	Decision	What was decided? State it clearly in one sentence.
3	Rationale	Why this option? The three to five strongest reasons.
4	Alternatives	What else was considered and why was it not chosen?
5	Consequences	What are the positive and negative consequences of this decision?
6	Review Date	When will this decision be reconsidered in light of new evidence?

WRITING THAT WORKS

- ✓ Subject line contains the decision or outcome.
- ✓ Recommendation before analysis — always.
- ✓ Plain English — no architecture jargon.
- ✓ Active voice: 'We recommend' not 'It is recommended.'
- ✓ One idea per sentence.
- ✓ Decision and owner clearly named.

WRITING THAT FAILS

- ✗ Subject line is a topic, not an action.
- ✗ Analysis builds to the recommendation — buried at the end.
- ✗ Technical vocabulary without translation.
- ✗ Passive voice throughout — removes accountability.
- ✗ Dense paragraphs with multiple ideas.
- ✗ Document ends without a clear next action.

SECTION 15

COMMUNICATION ANTI-PATTERNS

These are the most common communication failures that destroy credibility at the executive and board level. Each one is observable, diagnosable, and correctable. Review this section before every major communication.

AP1

The Architecture Lecture

Problem: Explaining the technical architecture in detail to an audience that needs the business outcome. Triggered by the belief that if the audience understood the technical complexity, they would approve the investment.

Fix: Reframe: 'What does this enable the business to do that it cannot do today?' Start there. The architecture is the appendix, not the presentation.

AP2

The Certainty Performance

Problem: Projecting false confidence about uncertain outcomes because the audience signals a preference for certainty. Builds short-term approval and long-term credibility damage.

Fix: Use the Risk-Adjusted Narrative. Accurate uncertainty is more credible than false precision.

AP3

The Endless Context

Problem: Spending 80% of the communication on background and context before reaching the recommendation. By the time the recommendation arrives, the audience has stopped listening.

Fix: Use BLUF or Pyramid Principle. Recommendation first. Context is the appendix.

AP4

The Passive Hedge

Problem: Using passive voice and hedged language to avoid accountability: 'It might be considered that...' 'There could be a case for...' This reads as low confidence, regardless of the content.

Fix: Use active voice with accountability: 'I recommend...' 'We will...' 'The risk is...'

AP5

The Jargon Shield

Problem: Using technical vocabulary as a signal of expertise rather than as a communication tool. Forces the audience to translate rather than engage.

Fix: For every technical term, ask: 'What is the plain English equivalent?' If a CFO would need to Google it, replace it.

AP6

The Disagreement Avoidance

Problem: Softening a recommendation to avoid conflict, until the recommendation no longer exists. Presenting 'options' when you have a clear view is a failure of leadership, not sensitivity.

Fix: State your recommendation. Then acknowledge the strongest counterargument. Then explain why your recommendation is still correct. Avoiding conflict in communication is not diplomacy.

AP7

The No-Ask Close

Problem: Ending a presentation or document without a clear call to action. 'I hope this was useful' is not a close. 'I need a decision by Friday' is.

Fix: Every communication must end with: a specific action, a named owner, and a deadline.

THE MASTER CHECKLIST

Before every significant communication, run through this checklist:

CHECKPOINT	QUESTION
Audience	Have I calibrated the register, abstraction level, and length to this specific audience?
Framework	Have I selected the right framework for this communication type? (Board → PP/SCR, Briefing → SBAR, Verbal → PREP)
BLUF	Does my opening sentence contain the recommendation or decision needed?
3 Lenses	Have I addressed the Business, Risk, and Investment dimensions?
Objections	Have I pre-empted the three most likely objections in the content?
Uncertainty	Have I communicated uncertainty accurately rather than performing false precision?
Ask	Does my communication end with a specific action, owner, and deadline?
Register	Is there any jargon, passive voice, or technical vocabulary that would require translation?